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Youth and the Changing Political Activist

Introduction

I think our parents' generation was more into street politics. Our generation is more politically aware but we have more opinions rather than actually going through it.

(Focus Group, Private University[1])

NO [not politically active] I am currently a student and during my studies I don't consider this as a healthy activity to be [involved] in.

(Madrassa Student, Male, Islamabad)

No one interested in politics. Can't change politics. In Islam woman cannot be allowed to take part in politics. We've observed.

(Focus Group, Government University[2])

The nature of political activism among young Pakistanis has changed over generations, the result of a state crackdown on student politics juxtaposed with an education curriculum that curtails possible expressions of dissent. These student quotes from three different groups of students testify to the extent to which students are disconnected from political action. As this chapter illustrates, political awareness is often confused with political activism, and interest in politics in general has decreased across generations, as stated by the student in the focus group at a private university in Karachi. Also, the idea of student politics is perceived to be antithetical to the idea of education, evident in the second quote of a student from KP who was studying at a madrassa in Islamabad. And a lack of interest in politics, combined with a particular understanding of Islam, especially in relation to female political activism, is another factor that has normalized apathy among students. This does not take away from the fact that in the past five years student movements have emerged, particularly in urban